

One Naught Use 'Ought'

An Essay on Hume's *A Treatise on Human Nature*

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In *A Treatise on Human Nature*, Hume analyzes the problems with his ethicist peers to push the study of ethics forward. Hume consistently sought a middle ground for the average person who wanted to understand philosophy. Hume believes that ethicists are in the clouds. While there is beauty in understanding the obscure, the common practice of analyzing every action associated with a concept is less a love for ethics and more a love for the decided concept. Abstruse philosophizing is what characterizes his complaint. Hume postulates that one loses sight of the larger and more evolved sense of self by analyzing every form of an action within a desired metaphor or analogy. In *A Treatise on Human Nature*, Hume creates the concept of the transcendental sense of self and moral distinctions, compares peers of his time to hedonists, and pushes forward the common understanding of morality to a more productive end.

Hume argues that moral distinctions come from a moral sense to refute and reorient his contemporaries' emphasis on virtue and broad moral rules. The ethicists of Hume's era focused on classifying actions as good or bad. According to Hume, if they attempted to do so, there must be a way to classify an action as good or bad. An example of this is Kant's simple rule, "One must never use people as a means to an end." Though this rule arguably applies to all people, to be "objective," it would have to apply to all things. If that is the case, then a dog that forces a person to clean up after it or a cat that makes a person pick up pencils after knocking them off would be morally bad. If there exist beings that are exempt from such broad and "objective" rules, the rules are not effective. Within actions, according to his contemporaries, there had to be

metrics to assess whether actions were good or bad. Hume suggests feelings because an action only receives a moral qualifier after it happens. Some never experience these actions, and some actions are context-dependent, so no actions are universally and objectively negative. If one characterizes each action, one risks analyzing how every person or object on earth is affected by any action. This line of thinking, according to Hume, is reductive and opens the door for anyone to morally excuse arguments based on arbitrary metrics. Essentially, if one tries to label an action or set of morals objectively, it risks forcing the discussion into a reductive line of reasoning; a reductive line of reasoning would either purposely obfuscate populations for the sake of argument or open the door to morally excusing atrocities. Further, if one appealed to a higher loyalty and suggested that rules are not the standard but instead God is, it would completely upend the modern understanding of ethics. According to Hume, religion upends the study of philosophical ethics by suggesting that morals are natural and needed to achieve heaven or a preferable afterlife. Religion contradicts the definition of philosophy. Ethical philosophy requires morals to be teachable and desirable for their own sake. The rule for knowledge in philosophy applies here as well. At a foundational level, objectively analyzing what one “ought” to do is reductive in Hume’s interpretation of ethics. Hume’s reputation stems from this line of thinking. He upends the standard study of ethics by providing a new path forward. Hume believes people have evolved to acquire the ability to learn ethics and that ethics can be taught. Teachability is a requirement for his argument. Hume proves this through the millions of abstract attachments people have evolved to develop. Some musicians have attachments to old, broken instruments; some take care of disabled pets; and some refuse to give up old and ratty stuffed animals. Since there are no uses or values in these examples at first glance, it would follow that any attachment has to be due to some abstract concept. This abstract concept has been named “sentimentality,”

and Hume believes examples like these prove that human morality has extended beyond basic human nature. Basic human nature would suggest that objects are useful so long as they fulfill their purpose and exercise their function. Aristotle's definition of the final cause of any object qualifies this. He defines the final cause as what the object does when it is flourishing, or its "purpose." If humans have evolved past the need for all objects and beings to serve a purpose, then it follows that attachments come from the more evolved moral sense. Instead of actions, Hume postulates that modern ethics should shift to general themes of morality. According to Hume, philosophers who seek objectivity should look at broader themes of morality rather than trying to fit actions into boxes. If one tries to analyze an action, it separates into good or bad. If it fits into good or bad, there must be a mechanism to do so. If a mechanism is objective, it applies to all objects. Since no objective measure applies to all objects, the process goes back to premise one. A philosopher must discover or prove the nature or value of actions. Since some people have never experienced an action and therefore have no positive or negative interpretation of the action, ethicists would overreach if they try to assign how a person "ought" to respond to an unknown action. Since there was no way to analyze every possible action, his contemporaries had been analyzing it on a falsely objective basis. If their process was falsely objective, it must be subjective. If their process is subjective, then ethicists have been operating on emotion. If they've been influenced and decided based on emotion, then ethicists search for positive and negative feelings for purpose and decision-making. Hedonists believe purpose comes from natural feelings, suggesting that life's purpose comes from trying to maximize pleasure. Since ethicists of Hume's time worked by maximizing pleasure in the form of "good morals," they were hedonists. Hume's understanding of moral distinctions from a moral sense comes through careful analysis of the process of his contemporaries as well as the origin of human ethics and

attachment. Hume claims that a moral sense is developed by evolving past the point of basic “function” and developing one’s sense of reason and purpose.

Continuing his initial argument, Hume believes those who judge an action do two things: assume actions are universal and work with false objectivity. Philosophers who assume actions are universal fail to consider the contextual dependence of actions. Most actions are context-based and require the use of analogies to expound. Since philosophers cannot possibly assess every scenario, the best result is analyzing most of the current Eurocentric views on morality. Therefore, all philosophers who assume actions are universal remain in the clouds, so people cannot understand what they talk about, which convinces them they are geniuses. Also, this is done based on the principle of hedonism, which many of these philosophers outwardly disagree with. As a result, philosophers convince themselves that actions are universal for the sake of argument, and poor arguments are as damaging as never studying ethics if and only if one posits false arguments as logical. Positing false arguments as true is simply spreading misinformation. Further, philosophers create a sense of false objectivity. Philosophers work, study, and argue within the rules of logic. Logical objectivity requires that universal rules apply to every variable in that system. If a toddler hands a daycare worker a toy, and it makes the worker happy, though the child did it in ignorance with no regard for the feelings of the attendant, it would follow that this is virtue through habituation and action. The child does a virtuous action and will develop those traits over time. However, there is no way to understand why the toddler did what it did because even the toddler did not know any better, so ethicists cannot possibly decide a motive for them. It does not serve a purpose in Aristotle’s virtue ethics; therefore, according to Hume, anyone who worked with those concepts has also wasted time considering motive in ethics. What is important are the concepts of needs and wants, action and

inaction. One ought not use “ought” at the risk of undermining the whole subject. Hume believes that by judging an action as good or bad, one convinces oneself they are objective to elicit a positive feeling or inherently self-gratify a sense of moral superiority.

Some have credited Hume with destroying the common understanding of ethics. However, this claim lacks the specificity needed to credit him. Before making such extreme claims, it is essential to set definitions. The Oxford Dictionary defines “destructive” as “tending to refute or disparage; negative and unhelpful.” For the sake of clarity, this definition will suffice. If this definition is suitable, then Hume’s refutation and all other rebuttals are inherently destructive. Modern philosophers understand the broader interpretation of ethics as what he disparages. Hume rebuts the concept of broad rules that characterize all actions and principles. *A Treatise on Human Nature* proves the study of broad rules misguided; instead, he points to the more evolved sense of human reason and moral sense. Although Hume disavows the common understanding of ethics, the treatise is never negative or unhelpful. Despite Hume’s characterization of the modern philosopher, he has no malice in his treatise. Instead, Hume proclaims his love for the study of ethics and wishes his peers to work toward a more productive end. It is then essential to assess if his method of shifting ethics is destructive or constructive. These qualifiers depend on how one interprets the definition. Hume’s destruction of the standard view of ethics strived to help the average budding philosopher understand a new form of ethics. Hume aims and succeeds in making ethics more accessible. Therefore, he adds more young philosophers to the population. Hume manages to be destructive and constructive to the common understanding of ethics. This “destruction” could be compared to Martin Luther’s 95 Theses. Luther did not write the theses to start the Lutheran religion. Instead, he aimed to criticize the church’s mission at that point. He was labeled “destructive” and heretical despite creating a new

viewpoint and adding to the community. Those who profit off the inaccessibility of the humanities for lower classes do this often. If people with power and wealth create a hierarchy and postulate that refutations are “destructive,” they stifle new thought. Those who eschew new understandings of the humanities are reductive or “destructive” to the study of ethics. Hiding or censoring new thoughts confines the search for objectivity into one path. Progress comes from being “destructive” to the common understanding. Shifting the standard is the foundation of innovation. Therefore, because Hume is objectively not destructive, he instead redirects efforts to a more productive path and influences ethical philosophers from this point on.

It would be reductive to belabor the definitional debate on “destruction.” Instead, one should understand potential flaws in Hume’s argument. Hume addresses the applicability of general principles as preferable to the analysis of individual actions. However, he provides few examples of these seemingly infinite relationships and attachments one could have. Failure to prove the truth of a contention does not mean it is false, though his argument could seem contradictory. Hume criticizes the analysis of individual actions, and in doing so, he pigeonholes himself into objectively analyzing every “general principle” in the broader understanding of ethics. Aristotle did this already. Aristotle uses virtue to characterize these broader principles of ethics. Hume suggests the study of virtue is misleading because it fits actions into broader principles for the purpose of self-gratification. However, that is what he does with the idea of evolved attachments and morals. If one has an attachment to a broken instrument, it could be due to their duty of justice to the item because it served that person for a time. Thus, that musician may feel responsible for taking care of it even after it breaks because they are a just person. This logic applies to the toddler example as well. If the toddler gives the toy to a daycare worker, the child would be classified as innocent or without reason. Despite the empirical lack of reason in

the toddler, they would be responsible for that action no matter the moral qualifier of the consequence. As Aristotle put it, one must take responsibility even for an action done in ignorance. If the child turned away from the worker, thereby making them feel ignored, one would be just as likely to criticize the child as they would to praise it for the opposite. Therefore, even actions done in ignorance or “without reason” can be assigned to virtue, even within Hume’s broader definitions of the general moral sense. If one can argue within Hume’s definitions to create characterizations of objects or beings and can apply what his peers called “universal concepts of ethics” universally, then Hume’s thesis would not stand.

Hume uses *A Treatise on Human Nature* to shift the common understanding of ethics toward a more productive future. He does this because he believes ethicists have reached a dead end. Instead of characterizing actions and intent, Hume believes in characterizing broader moral principles behind the more evolved moral sense. Hume argues that judging an action as bad serves no one but the judge. Using logic, he argues that since there is no objective way to analyze intent, it does not matter. Further, saying there is only serves the philosopher. The process inherently is self-gratification and fosters a sense of false objectivity. His work upends the common understanding of ethics but also introduces a new method of pontification. Therefore, Hume is both destructive and constructive to the study of ethics. Despite his impressive argumentation, Hume does leave room for refutation. His contradictory support for “general principles” of morality and disapproval of “virtue” and the common understanding of ethics is a massive flaw. Hume argues that humans have evolved past “natural” morality and have developed teachable moral senses. Thus, according to Hume, fitting actions into broader principles wastes time. The room for refutation comes from his inability to define how “broader principles of moral sense” function. In essence, they function similarly to the common

understanding of virtue. He circled the philosophical spectrum to end up on his opponents' side. Hume introduces a revolutionary line of thinking in *A Treatise on Human Nature*. He criticizes the self-gratifying nature of his contemporaries' false objectivity and pushes ethics in a new direction. Despite flaws in his argument, he was far from destructive and proved that one ought say 'ought' or risk undermining the objectivity of philosophy.